

TIM O'BRIEN

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Education

University of Chicago

M.A. in International Relations, with Honors (GPA: 3.88)

B.A. in Political Science, with Honors (GPA: 3.75)

Chicago, IL

2025 – 2026

2021 – 2025

London School of Economics

The General Course, International Relations (GPA: 3.93)

London, UK

2023 – 2024

Research

Publications

“Does Economic Globalization Promote Democracy? An Empirical Investigation into the Political Consequences of Economic Integration”

Berkeley Economic Review, forthcoming 2026. B.A. thesis. Advisor: Susan Stokes.

Working Papers

“Innovation without Democratization: The Political Limits of Technological Change”

M.A. thesis, University of Chicago. Advisor: Scott Gehlbach.

Abstract: Innovation has been positively linked to a variety of economic outcomes, including long-run development, productivity, and human capital. But its political effects have received far less attention. To address this imbalance, I investigate the effect of innovation on democracy and two intermediate outcomes, state capacity and capital mobility, using a shift-share instrumental variables strategy on a panel of 187 countries from 1995 to 2015. This design exploits quasi-random variation in global patenting growth across different fields of knowledge to identify the effects of innovation. I find that innovation exerts no detectable effect on democracy, but strongly and positively increases both state capacity and capital mobility. A one-standard-deviation increase in log patents per million residents raises state capacity by approximately half a standard deviation and capital mobility by roughly a quarter of a standard deviation. I argue that the null effect of innovation on democracy stems from the offsetting influences of these two forces. State capacity reduces the elites' costs of repression and therefore inhibits democratization, while capital mobility decreases the costs of conceding to democracy and thus promotes it. Consistent with this account, I find that innovation widens the gap between the state's capacity and society's ability to hold it accountable. My estimates are robust across several specifications, measures, and samples.

Public Writing

“A Crisis of Confidence: European Public Opinion in the Trump Era”

Chicago Council on Global Affairs, *Running Numbers*, 2025.

Work Experience

Saïd Business School, University of Oxford

Feb 2026 – Present

Research Fellow, Prof. Kejia Hu

- Implement LLM-based batch inference to test result robustness in managerial economics studies
- Conduct Monte Carlo simulations to assess bias in regression-based estimators
- Design forecasting models combining statistical and machine learning methods

Knowledge Lab, University of Chicago

Nov 2025 – Present

Research Assistant, Prof. James Evans and Dr. Nadav Kunievsky

- Build Python, Spark, and LLM pipelines matching 26,000 grant applications to 300 million publications
- Conduct econometric analysis on research funding effects in R, Python, and Stata
- Develop classification models using supervised and unsupervised deep learning

Chicago Council on Global Affairs

Jan 2025 – Sep 2025

Intern, Public Opinion and US Foreign Policy

- Cleaned and maintained large-scale proprietary survey datasets on U.S. foreign policy issues
- Produced topline reports on American public opinion toward Asia, Europe, Ukraine, the Middle East, trade policy, and multilateralism
- Published analysis on European attitudes toward the U.S. in the *Running Numbers* blog

Chicago Project on Security and Threats, University of Chicago

Jun 2023 – Aug 2023

Research Assistant, Prof. Robert Pape

- Updated the “Threats Matrix” database (2001–2023) of threats toward American politicians
- Aided in the revision and implementation of standardized data-coding protocols for the research team
- Created data visualizations and case studies on charged perpetrators of threats

Awards and Honors

Honors, M.A. in International Relations, University of Chicago

2026

Awarded to the top 15% of the cohort on the basis of the M.A. thesis.

M.A. Director’s Merit Scholarship, University of Chicago

2025

Merit award from the Committee on International Relations.

Teaching and Service

University of Chicago, Department of Political Science

Jan 2025 – Apr 2025

Undergraduate Advisor

- Evaluated job talks by 6 candidates for 2 instructional professorships in social science methodology
- Advised prospective political science majors on coursework and career paths

University of Chicago Neighborhood Schools Program

Nov 2022 – Jun 2023

Teaching Assistant

- Tutored ~50 low-income students on Chicago’s South Side as part of a UChicago student team

Skills and Training

Coursework: Mathematics for Social Science (Calculus, Linear Algebra, Probability Theory), Applied Regression Analysis, Causal Inference, Machine Learning, Hierarchical Linear Models

Statistical Software: R, Python, Stata, SQL, Spark

Research Computing: $\text{\LaTeX}$, Git, Shell/Bash, high-performance cluster computing (SLURM)

Data Analysis: Causal inference & econometrics, machine learning, LLM batch inference

Languages: English (native); Spanish (working proficiency)

Interests: Rubik’s Cube speed-solving ([top 0.03% worldwide](#)); basketball

References

Professor Scott Gehlbach

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Professor Susan Stokes

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Dr. Nadav Kunievsky

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